

Caracal caracal

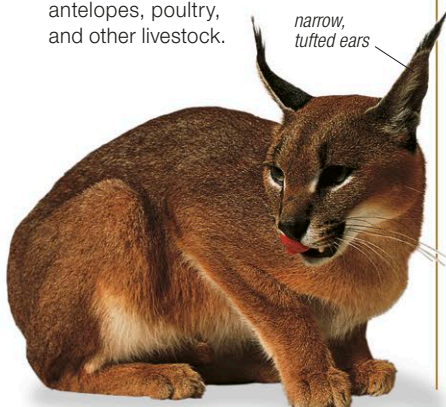
Caracal



Length 24–41 in
(61–106 cm)
Tail 7½–14 in
(19.5–35 cm)
Weight 13–42 lb
(6–19 kg)
Location Africa, W., C.,
and S. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Also called the desert lynx, because of its arid scrubby habitat, the caracal is tawny or reddish, although—as with many cats—occasional black (melanic) individuals occur (see black panther, p.206). It is famed for its ability to spring 10 ft (3 m) vertically and to “bat” flying birds with its paw. Its main foods are rodents, hyraxes, hares, small antelopes, poultry, and other livestock.



narrow,
tufted ears

Leptailurus serval

Serval



Length 23–36 in
(59–92 cm)
Tail 8–15 in
(20–38 cm)
Weight 15–30 lb
(7–13.5 kg)
Location Africa
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

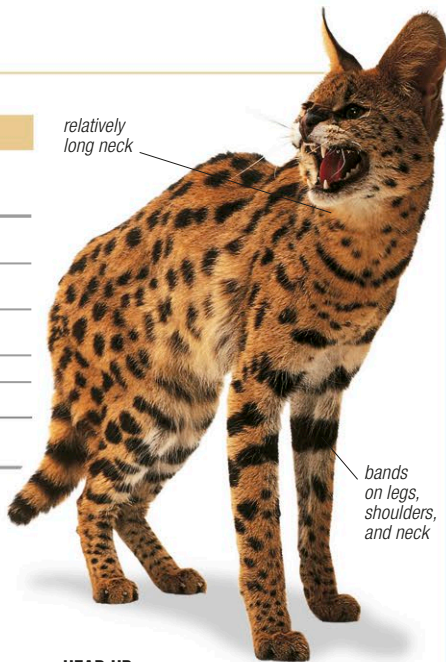


Resembling a small cheetah, with its lean body and long limbs, the serval has yellowish fur with dark spots. It prefers to live among reeds and rushes fringing wetlands. Here it hunts rats and similar prey, helping control rodents and thereby aiding farmers (servals rarely attack livestock). The average litter of 2 young is born after 73 days’ gestation.

CAT POUNCE

Having located prey, usually at dusk, and mainly by hearing, the serval excels at the cat pounce. It leaps up to 13 ft (4 m) horizontally and more than 3¼ ft (1 m) high, to strike the victim with its forepaws. This cat eats rats and similar-sized rodents, birds, fish, and large insects such as locusts. Frogs are a favorite with wetland-dwelling servals.

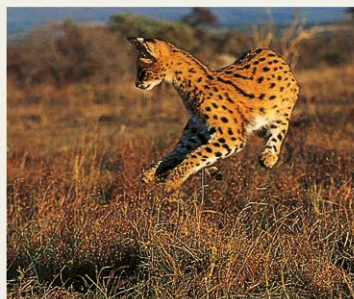
relatively
long neck



bands
on legs,
shoulders,
and neck

HEAD UP

The serval’s relatively long legs and neck elevate its head to 30 in (75 cm) above ground, enabling it to see and hear clearly in long grass.



Pardofelis marmorata

Marbled cat



Length 18–24 in
(45–62 cm)
Tail 14–22 in
(35.5–55 cm)
Weight 4½–11 lb
(2–5 kg)
Location S. to S.E. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Near threatened



A little-known species, found mainly in moist, lowland tropical forest, the marbled cat resembles a small clouded leopard, although they are not related. It is long-tailed, a proficient climber, and probably a nocturnal predator of squirrels, birds, and similar tree dwellers. Data being collected in Thailand should help to shed some light on this species. Gestation is 66–82 days, litter size 1–4, and sexual maturity is at 21 months.

Felis silvestris

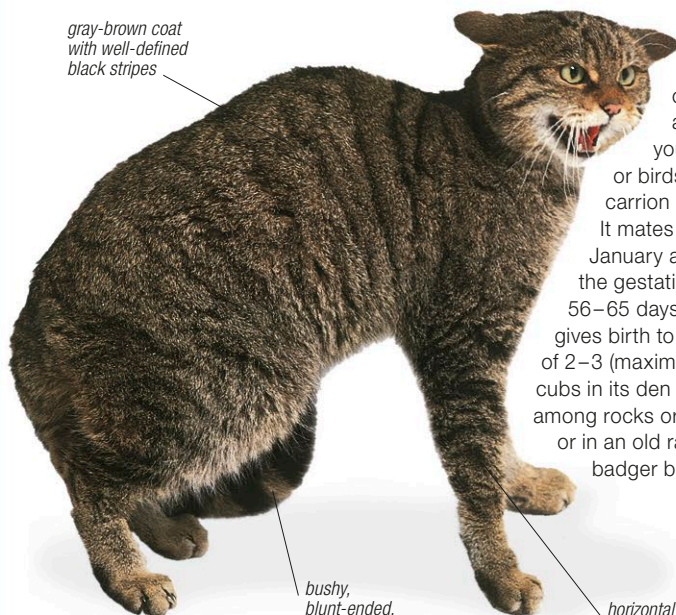
Wild cat



Length 16–29 in
(40.5–74 cm)
Tail 9–14½ in
(22–37 cm)
Weight 4½–16 lb
(2–7.3 kg)
Location Europe, W. and
C. Asia, Africa
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



gray-brown coat
with well-defined
black stripes



bushy,
blunt-ended,
black-tipped tail

The wild cat resembles a slightly larger, heavier-built, usually longer-furred (especially in winter) version of the domestic tabby cat. The species interbreeds with domestic cats, of which the African subspecies *Felis silvestris lybica* is presumed to be the ancestor. The wild cat’s preferred habitat is mixed broad-leaved woodland, but habitat loss and amenity use of woods has driven it to marginal habitats such as conifer forest, rocky upland, moor, scrub, swamp, and coast. It feeds on rabbits

and small rodents, such as rats, mice, voles, and lemmings. This cat climbs well and catches young squirrels or birds in the branches; carrion is also eaten. It mates between January and March and the gestation period is 56–65 days. The female gives birth to an average of 2–3 (maximum up to 4) cubs in its den in a tree hole, among rocks or tree roots, or in an old rabbit or badger burrow.

Felis chaus

Jungle cat



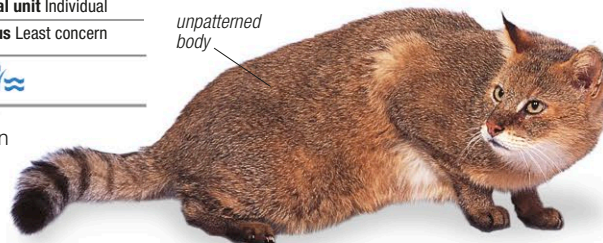
Length 24–34 in
(61–85 cm)
Tail 8–12 in
(20–31 cm)
Weight 5½–26 lb
(2.5–12 kg)
Location W., C., S., and
S.E. Asia, N.E. Africa
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Despite its main common name, this slender, long-legged cat is also known more aptly as

the swamp or reed cat. It hunts along marshes, river banks, shores, and also ditches and ponds around human settlements, taking mammals up to the size of coypu, birds (including poultry), reptiles, and, being a strong swimmer, fish and amphibians. Female and male may stay together, and both protect the cubs.

unpatterned
body



Felis margarita

Sand cat



Length 15½–20½ in
(39–52 cm)
Tail 9–12 in
(23–31 cm)
Weight 3¼–7¾ lb
(1.5–3.5 kg)
Location N. Africa, W., C.,
and S.W. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Surviving on fluids in its food and very little additional water, the blunt-clawed sand cat digs well

for its main prey of gerbils and similar rodents, as well as an occasional lizard or snake. It also excavates a den for daytime shelter. The average litter of 3 grows quickly and may be independent in just 6 months.

